

AFFIRMATIVE ACTION FOR **WOMEN**

Affluent parents understand that the income-generating opportunities facing men and women in this country are very different. These parents tend to have their own form of economic affirmative action. Consider the following facts:

◆ Women account for 46 percent of the workers in this country but represent fewer than 20 percent of the individuals who earn \$100,000 or more annually. In 1980, fewer than 40,000 women had annual incomes of \$100,000 or more. In 1995, approximately 400,000 women were in this income category. This translates into a tenfold increase. By the year 2000, more than 600,000 women will have incomes in the six-figure-and-higher category. But, again, as in 1995, there will still be five men for every woman in this income category.

◆ Women have made significant progress in regard to the proportion who graduate from professional schools. In 1970, for example, only 8.4 percent of medical school graduates were women. In 1995, nearly 40 percent were women. In 1970, women accounted for about 6 percent of all law school graduates; in 1995, they made up nearly 45 percent. A high-status occupational title does not automatically translate into a high income, however. A recent census headline stated: “Earnings gaps [in 1995] still apparent *even* for professional degree holders.” In this regard, women employed in professional occupations in 1995 earned only 49.2 percent of what men in professional occupations earned.

◆ How do the salaries of men and women in high-income-producing occupations compare? See the results of our analysis in [Table 6-3](#). In twenty out of twenty of the highest income-producing occupations, women on average earn significantly less than their male counterparts. For example, female physicians earn only 52 percent of what male physicians earn, female dentists earn 57.4 percent of what male dentists earn, female podiatrists earn 55 percent of what male podiatrists earn, and female lawyers earn 57.5 of what male lawyers earn.